

Qantas Airways, Cabin Crew Workforce & Flight Reliability, 2022 to 2025

From Priority to Decision Prototype

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Part 1: Executive Proposal

1.1 Organizational Priority and Context

The priority is to improve Qantas's flight cancellation rate compared to its major competitor, Virgin Australia to strengthen the load factor by ensuring well supported cabin crew workforce across flight operations.

Qantas is one of the leading Airlines in Australia. But in recent years it faces some major operational challenges. One of the is the flight cancellation issue. On 8th October 2024, the Federal Court ordered Qantas to pay \$100 million in penalties for misleading consumers by selling tickets for flights it had already decided to cancel (Australian Competition and Consumer Commission 2024). Due to this scandal, CEO Alan Joyce had to resign. After the next year, Qantas still failed to solve the issue. In June 2025, Qantas Group cancelled 3.2% of scheduled flights compared to Virgin Australia's 1.6% (Australian Competition and Consumer Commission 2025). There are key factors behind cancelling a flight. One of the key reasons is the staffing issue. While focus on it, it's found that there was a cabin crew unsatisfaction tension in Qantas in 2023. It is solved in 2024 increasing 30% of the rumination (eGlobal Travel Media 2024). But the question is, by doing it does it solved the staffing issue? It can be reflected in the dashboard. But the interesting fact meanwhile, Virgin Australia won the World's Best Cabin Crew award in 2026. Interesting!

1.2 Evolution of the Priority

The priority has gone through 3 changes. Initially in part 1, it focused broadly on on-time performance and delayed routes. But in the part 2, it also focused towards the effect of load factor, share price. Also, it introduces a buffer time for delay routes which had a major lack in strategic and realistic dept. Then in the final priority it got a strategic direction. The issue of the flight cancellation and the cabin crew staffing and the relation on both got highlighted. Thus, the final priority and the supporting questions are set through this evolution.

1.3 Decision Making Opportunity and Strategic Relevance

Qantas is now passing a crucial period in its operational and reputational history. The ACCC actively monitoring cancellation rates. The new CEO Vanessa Hudson is working to rebuild public trust following the ghost flights scandal. On the other hand, Virgin Australia is steadily strengthening its service reputation advantage. Against this backdrop, the dashboard is designed

to move the CEO from awareness to decision readiness across six interconnected questions fronts for decisions.

The first decision this analysis enables is whether Qantas's cancellation issue is a recent or a persistent structural gap.

The second decision front examines the competitive positioning in load factor for both of the competitors.

The third decision examines whether Qantas is facing a genuine retention problem relative to Virgin Australia.

It is evident that after the covid pandemic the number of flight passenger increases. The fourth question examines the cabin crew hiring growth divided by the passenger growth, means the ratio.

The fifth question enables to determine whether crew service quality is worth or not by benchmarking the globally recognized service award.

The final decision enables to identify which specific domestic routes are most severely burdened by cancellations.

1.4 Dashboard Concept and Rationale

The dashboard is designed as an executive decision support tool. It begins with four KPI cards. These initiates the key tensions, Qantas cancellations vs Virgin Australia cancellation rate in 2025, load factor gap and the crew retention.

From there, it starts through three structured sections. The first shows the cancellation and load factor trends. The second examines cabin crew experience and sufficiency including turnover trends, hiring growth ratio and service recognition.

The third identifies route level analysis of Qantas where the cancellations are mostly concentrated. This sequencing is intentional to move the decisions towards the most actionable operational insight. Furthermore, filters for airline and year allow the analysis to respond to the specific queries.

1.5 Evidence Base

This analysis draws on multiple reliable data sources from 2022 to 2025. First, flight cancellation data were obtained from BITRE (Bureau of Infrastructure, Transport and Regional Economics 2025). Next, passenger, employee, and workforce information were collected from the annual and sustainability reports of both airlines. In addition, cabin crew service recognition data were sourced from Airline Ratings (AirlineRatings.com 2026). Also, Statista provides the world's flight passenger growth information (Statista 2026) and ACCC reports guides through the understanding of the Airlines competition (Australian Competition and Consumer Commission 2026).

1.6 Decision Insights from the Dashboard

Insight 1: Qantas cancellation rate remains higher than Virgin Australia's. Meanwhile Virgin Australia is gaining the Load factor better than Qantas.

Qantas cancelled 3.2% of flights in 2025. Virgin Australia cancelled only 1.7%. Although Qantas has improved from 2022, but the competitive gap still widened. It affects the Load factor. The Virgin Australia's load factor is slightly higher, but still higher than the Qantas.

Insight 2: Qantas has more experienced crew than Virgin Australia. Still, it has never won a Best Cabin Crew Service Award.

Qantas's turnover declined to 5.4% in 2025. It's lower than Virgin Australia's 11.1%. This suggests Qantas holds more experienced crew. However, Virgin Australia has achieved the Best Cabin Crew award in 2026 by the Airline Ratings. Not the first time. Consecutively eight times. Qantas has won zero times on this basis from any recognized organizations.

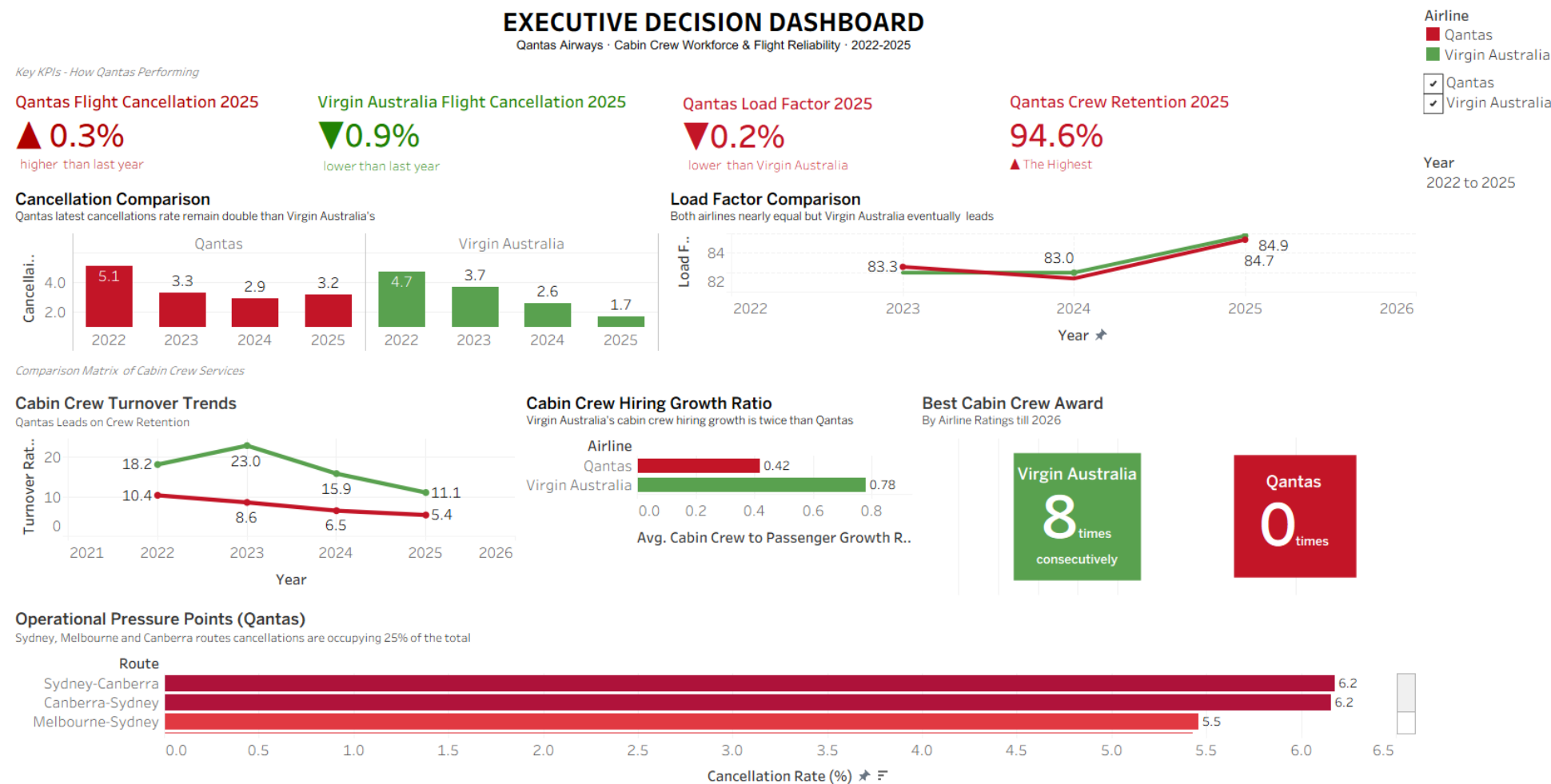
Insight 3: Both airlines are growing load factors similarly. But Qantas's cabin crew hiring is not keeping pace with passenger growth. It's almost half than the Virgin Australia's.

Both airlines are in competitive position on load factor since 2023. However, Qantas's average cabin crew to passenger growth ratio is at 0.42 while Virgin Australia's 0.78. Consequently, while the passenger demand grows equally, Qantas is lag behind.

Insight 4: Sydney-Canberra and Melbourne-Sydney and vice-versa routes account for about 25% of Qantas's total domestic cancellations.

Canberra-Sydney, Melbourne-Sydney and vice versa routes each record cancellation rates between 5.4% and 6.2%. Together these four routes account for approximately 25% of Qantas's total domestic cancellations.

1.7 A Snapshot of Executive Decision Dashboard



Part: 2 Dashboard Commentary and Analysis

2.1 Overview of Dashboard Design and Key Insights

Flight cancellations happen for multiple reasons. These include weather conditions, technical or mechanical failures, crew shortages, air traffic control restrictions and airport operational issues like as runway closures or sometimes security threats. These factors can be grouped into four strategic categories. Weather, technical, workforce and operations. While all four categories contribute to cancellations, this dashboard focuses specifically on the workforce. More precisely, it centers on cabin crew sufficiency and service quality.

The dashboard is designed into three phases. The first phase starts with four KPI cards. These cards establish the key tensions immediately. Qantas's cancellations risen and remains higher than Virgin Australia's in 2025. At the same time, the load factor is slightly lagging behind than Virgin Australia. However, Qantas crew retention in 2025 is at its highest recorded level of 94.6%. This creates a significant tension. Crew retention is strong. Still cancellations and load factors are not reflecting that improvement. The next question comes, what happened in the previous years as well?

The second phase answers it showing trends from 2022 to 2025. It reveals a pattern. Qantas cancellation rates have been higher than Virgin Australia's throughout the last four years. Also, Virgin Australia is competing almost equally on load factor, slightly but still higher. This raises a critical question. If Qantas has the more experienced cabin crew, why does the cancellation gap persist?

The third phase addresses this question directly. It examines three cabin crew workforce metrics. Crew turnover trends, hiring growth ratio and service recognition. First, Qantas's crew turnover rate over the past four years is about half of Virgin Australia's. Lower turnover means higher experienced cabin crews. That's great. Also, according to Statista, the global flight passenger number has the best rising trend. Thus, the question arises. Is Qantas crew hiring growth is keeping pace with demand?

To examine this, a cabin crew hiring growth ratio was calculated in the third phase. The number of new crew added divided by the increase in passengers carried. A ratio closer to one indicates that crew capacity is growing in line with passenger demand. The data shows that Virgin Australia's

average hiring growth ratio of 0.78 is nearly doubled than Qantas's ratio of 0.42. Means, Virgin Australia is growing its cabin crew workforce at twice than Qantas.

The service recognition metric adds a further dimension. Virgin Australia has won the World's Best Cabin Crew award continuously eight times. It is recognized by Airline Ratings in 2026. Qantas has not won this award once.

Finally, the dashboard closes with a route level analysis. The Sydney-Canberra and Melbourne-Sydney and vice versa routes together account for approximately 25% of all Qantas cancellations.

2.2 How the Dashboard Supports Strategic Decision-Making

This dashboard is designed to inform executive judgement. The narrative flow moves deliberately from context to tension to action. The competitive position is established first. Without this context, the middle section of the cabin crew analysis would lack strategic meaning.

The cabin crew performance matrix then continues the key tension. Qantas has strong retention but a low hiring growth ratio. It has experienced crew but no external service recognition.

The route level section at the bottom translates the strategic conversation into an operational one. It answers the question of where, not just why. By identifying the specific corridors where cancellation rates are highest, Qantas leadership can consider geographically targeted responses.

Interactivity further enhances the dashboard's decision support capability. The airline filter allows Qantas and Virgin Australia data to be viewed in isolation or side by side. The year filter enables trend analysis across specific periods.

2.3 Assumptions, Limitations, and Future Improvements

Assumptions

Direct cabin crew numbers are not publicly available. The total employee figures from Qantas and Virgin Australia Annual Reports are used as a proportionate representation. This is supported by Retensa (2026). It identifies cabin crew as the largest airline employee group with the highest turnover rate.

Limitations

The dashboard does not capture all contributors to flight cancellations. Weather, mechanical failures, and air traffic control delays are significant factors that are not represented in the current data. Furthermore, the load factor data covers domestic routes only.

Future Improvements

First, integration with the BITRE API would enable near real time cancellation data. It will also support quarterly or monthly updates rather than annual ones. Secondly, incorporating passenger satisfaction scores and on time performance data would provide a more complete picture of the service reliability gap between Qantas and Virgin Australia.

2.4 Ethical and Privacy Considerations

All data used in this dashboard is drawn from publicly available sources. No personal, individually identifiable or confidential data has been used at any point.

The intent is to inform investment decisions. Not to monitor or evaluate individual's staff. This aligns with the Australian Privacy Act 1988.

Finally, all data sources are listed in the Tableau workbook's dedicated Data Sources worksheet with working hyperlinks. This ensures full traceability and allows any stakeholder to verify the evidence.

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